mandal also had an IT head. Mathura, in the Braj region, for example, has thirty-two mandals. Each of them has a separate IT head. Their work centred on organising digital meetings and getting each booth president in the city to create official BJP WhatsApp groups in their areas.

'IT heads are different and sangathan heads are different,' explained a BJP district general secretary over hot chai in Mathura's Holi Gate area. 'If we want to do an online meeting here in Holi Gate mandal, then the district IT head will check the IDs and the Holi Gate IT head will coordinate. Others will connect with him.'[51]

A key priority of the IT heads is to organise WhatsApp groups at the booth level. Of approximately 2,100 polling booths in Mathura, local leaders estimated that they had active WhatsApp groups in 70 per cent (1,500–1,600) of them by July 2020. For the party, these WhatsApp groups performed two functions: as platforms to disseminate outward uniform messaging, but equally for socials listening from the ground up. Amit Shah outlined this approach in an address to the BJP's social media workers in September 2018 in Kota, Rajasthan.

Their work, Shah told them, had three objectives: one, data, research and analysis; two, actioning data through electronic means by samvad (communication) from 'bottom to the top and from top to the bottom'; and three, maximum spread of messaging. To achieve these aims, he asked them to organise in three ways: put together a team for data, research and analysis, a team for expansion and a creative team. 'This [political] war is such,' he said, 'only he can win who has the strength for spreading [faelaav].' He argued, 'Neither fire nor air have the power, have the power that is with those who have the power to spread [faelaav]. The one who spreads [*jo fael jaata hai*] becomes powerful, and youth have the capacity to spread.' Before the UP election in 2017, he claimed that the BJP had as many as 32 lakh people in its WhatsApp groups in the state (15 lakh and 17 lakh).[52]

The use of digital technology would not have been as impactful without the physical reordering of the party and its ground-level sangathan. The impact of this booth-based structure was such that, when the BJP faced nationwide protests against the Citizenship